DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Why Is God's Good Greater Than His Punishment?

Daat Tevunot §132-133

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §132-133
Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 8 June 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Two emanations

Last time we saw that even within the bad, good is never totally destroyed. A trace always remains, like the seed. Now the Ramhal explains how the world is rectified (§132).

When Hashem created the first emanation, He also created the possibility of it being dimmed. That dimming is what lets evil exist, as we learned in Section 5. But Hashem wants the good to win in the end. So there is a second emanation that works against the first, a check and balance that stops the bad from taking over more than is needed. The Rabbi summed it up: we need bad, so there is the dimming, but to make sure it does not take control there is a second flow. This is the first step in the rectification of creation.

Evil pushed to the lowest level

The Ramhal then says that Hashem made different levels of emanation. The Rabbi explained that this refers to the ten sefirot. On each level Hashem distances the bad from the good as far as possible. He does not destroy it, because while there is free choice the bad has to exist. He pushes it to the margins.

Footnotes 85 and 89 in the English edition set it out. First the highest level was rectified and its evil pushed away. That evil was not destroyed but joined the evil of the level below. Then that level was rectified, and the evil of both joined the third level, and so on. In the end all the evil of every level is gathered into one general category attached to the lowest level, the tenth. Even that level was partly rectified, but not completely, or evil would cease to exist.

The Rabbi pictured it this way: on each of the ten levels there is some bitul, some ability for bad, but each time it is pushed down, until it all collects at the bottom. Again, "there's no such thing as a bad emanation". There are only perfect emanations that are dimmed. Asked whether this happened before Adam, the Rabbi said yes. Adam could not have sinned without the first emanation, and Gan Eden could not have been paradise without the second.

The Rabbi stressed the word "distances". The bad is not abolished. It is sidelined, kept on the edges of each level, and its power is greatly weakened. As footnote 85 puts it, originally evil had

access to even the highest levels of the divine emanation. Now it can only reach from below, by attaching itself to the lowest level.

Why good outweighs bad

This lowering of evil is one of Hashem's great rectifications, and it is why the "attribute of good is greater than the attribute of punishment". The Rabbi brought the Ten Commandments: Hashem visits sin to the third and fourth generation but shows kindness to the thousandth. Hazal read this as two thousand generations against four, five hundred times more. Why? Because the good keeps its proper place on every level, while the bad has all been pushed down to the bottom.

When one rises, the other falls

Evil is still there, though, so rectification is still a process. The Ramhal brings the verse in Yehezkel, "I will be filled from the ruin". On the simple level it is about the destruction of the Temple. The Hakhamim (the Rabbi pointed to the reference to Megillah 6a in the brackets) apply it to Yaakov and Esav: when one rises, the other falls. Good and bad depend on each other. When good grows, bad sinks further, and when bad grows, good sinks.

So our avodah is clear. Hashem has given us instructions for strengthening the good: the Torah and the misvot. By keeping them, the bad is pushed further and further down, "and then the world will eventually become perfected". The Rabbi put it plainly: if we all did what He told us to do, the bad would be pushed all the way down and gone.

The Neshamah's response and the end of Section 6

In §133 the Neshamah says that all this is now clear. It shows that the world is not random. Everything was made with great wisdom to reach the final purpose, complete perfection.

The Rabbi then summarised Section 6:

1. The levels of Adam before and after the sin, the three levels.
2. The source of destruction is a lack of connection between the parts of creation.
3. Within the bad, good is never totally destroyed. A trace always remains.
4. The structure of the bad: it is pushed down level by level, it rises when good falls and falls when good rises, and in the end it will be eradicated in the final, general tikkun.

He noted that the group was now more than halfway through the book. He asked everyone to review the summary of Section 6 and the summary of all the sections at the back of the English edition before the revision class on Monday and the start of Section 7.

Summary

- A first emanation is dimmed to let evil exist, and a second holds it in check so it does not take over.
- On each of the ten levels the evil is pushed down, until all of it is gathered at the lowest level.

- This is why Hashem's measure of good is far greater than His measure of punishment: two thousand generations against four.
- Good and bad rise and fall against each other, like Yaakov and Esav. Torah and misvot push the bad down.
- This ends Section 6, which leads to the final tikkun, when evil is totally removed.

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